

1. Chapter 1 — Introduction

1.1. The Problem Kripke Left Open

Saul Kripke's modal, epistemic, and semantic arguments in *Naming and Necessity* and "Identity and Necessity" establish that proper names are rigid designators: a name picks out the same individual in every possible world in which that individual exists. The arguments are compelling, and the conclusion is by now a standard starting point in the philosophy of language. What the arguments establish is what rigid designators *do*. What they do not establish, and what Kripke himself does not undertake to establish, is what cognitive operation makes the doing possible.

The gap is specifically metasemantic. A formal apparatus can stipulate that a term holds its referent fixed across worlds. The stipulation can be written down and its logical consequences can be worked out. But stipulation is not explanation. When Kripke writes that reference is fixed by an "initial baptism" and transmitted through a "chain of communication," he describes the practice in which rigidity lives without describing the cognitive operation that makes the practice possible. A baptismal act coordinates a word with an individual; a chain of communication preserves the coordination. Neither is a logical relation. Both are things that cognitive systems do.

The gap is not an accident of Kripke's exposition. It reflects a pattern running through modern analytic philosophy of language: a tendency to take formal operations — assignment functions, descriptive satisfaction, model-theoretic interpretation — as if they could do the full work of tying words to things in the world. Russell restricted genuine naming to acquaintance with immediate sense data because anything more, on his picture, would have to operate through descriptions. Quine declared existence to be the value of a bound variable, absorbing the question of what bound variables refer to into the formal apparatus itself. Lewis built a modal metaphysics in which every possible world is a fully specified totality, with actuality as a merely indexical feature of the world we happen to occupy. These positions differ widely, but they share a structural commitment: formal operations internal to the linguistic system are taken to be sufficient for what we ordinarily think of as reference. Kripke's own account is the counterweight to this pattern — his appeal to baptism and causal chains is precisely the recognition that reference to a particular cannot be secured by formal operations alone. What Kripke leaves unanalyzed is the cognitive operation that baptism performs and the mechanism by which its result is preserved once the baptismal community is gone. The dissertation takes up this analysis.

This matters because reference to a particular is not generated by linguistic machinery operating on itself. No tightening of the network of words produces grip on an individual. Descriptions can locate an object of which one has no independent grip, but only by specifying conditions that something in the world happens to satisfy — and what they locate is whoever satisfies the conditions, not the individual as such. Grip on an individual comes from a different direction: from coordination with experience, from using a word at the point where it meets an encounter. Kripke's semantics inherits whatever this coordination accomplishes. The dissertation's question is what the coordination consists in and how the semantics depends on it.

1.2. Two Operations of Fixing

The dissertation distinguishes, from the outset, two operations by which a linguistic element can be tied to a value. They are different operations that do different work, and the distinction between them is the backbone of the positive account developed in Chapters 4 and 5.

The first operation is value-fixing through structures internal to the linguistic system. A variable under assignment is tied to a domain element by the assignment function. A definite description picks out whoever satisfies its conditions. A logical specification singles out what meets its constraints. A mathematical construction yields a specific object through the structural relations that define it. In each case, the tying is completed within the linguistic network — through descriptive content, through the formal apparatus of quantification, through structural specification. The dissertation will call this *A-grounding*, following the analogy with assignment in model theory, though the operation is broader than assignment in the strict sense. *A-grounding* is the operation that does not reach outside the linguistic system.

The second operation is value-fixing through coordination with something outside the linguistic

system. When a speaker looks at a chair and uses the word “chair” to pick out that particular chair, the tying is not achieved through descriptive content or formal specification. It is achieved through a cognitive coordination: the word meets the present object through perceptual engagement, and the meeting itself constitutes the tying. The dissertation will call this *R-grounding*, where the R indicates referential, in the sense of reaching out to something. R-grounding requires the presence or perceptual availability of what is being referred to. It is the operation that reaches outside.

The two operations are not rivals. Each does work the other cannot do. A-grounding is indispensable for formal reasoning, for mathematics, for descriptions when they function descriptively, for talk that does not pretend to reach any particular. R-grounding is indispensable for reference to individuals in the world. The tradition often treats A-grounding as sufficient for both jobs; Kripke is the signal exception, having seen that reference to particulars requires something formal operations cannot supply. What Kripke did not do, and what the dissertation undertakes, is to describe the non-formal operation at the cognitive level and to follow its consequences through the transition from live encounter to later absence.

The operations will be developed formally in Chapter 4, where the analytical core of the dissertation introduces the PRU distinction between object-mode and concept-mode and defines the grounding operations in its terms. For Chapter 1, what matters is that the dissertation distinguishes these two operations and treats them as non-interchangeable.

1.3. The Thesis

The dissertation advances a single thesis. Rigid designation in the Kripkean sense is the social stabilization of a more primitive phenomenon — *local rigidity* — present whenever a word coordinates with an experienced instance through R-grounding. When I track an object with my senses and use a word to pick it out, the coordination is rigid: the word picks out that individual without descriptive mediation, and modal claims about it carry no scope ambiguity. There is nothing for scope to interact with; the word just points, and what it points at is what the modal claim is about. Names inherit this character through an act of baptism that takes the coordination achieved in demonstrative encounter and vests it in a new linguistic device — a proper name — whose standing function is to carry the coordination into absence.

The thesis has two parts. The first concerns the origin of rigidity: local rigidity is the primitive phenomenon, produced by live R-grounding in demonstrative encounter. The second concerns how rigidity persists once the original encounter is over. Here the account has to handle a fact that has been underdescribed in the literature: R-grounding requires active coordination with a present particular, and after the particular is gone — after the chair leaves, after Aristotle dies — R is no longer available. Contemporary speakers who use the name “Aristotle” cannot be performing R-grounding with Aristotle; they have no access to him. Some other operation must be at work.

The dissertation argues that contemporary name use proceeds through A-grounding, where the descriptive and testimonial material accumulated around a name serves as the speaker’s cognitive handle. This does not make the account descriptivist. The descriptive material does not define the referent — the referent was fixed at baptism, through a real R-grounding with a real individual — but it does play a specific role in how contemporary speakers anchor their use of the name. Proper names, as a category of linguistic item, are treated by competent speakers as tracking unique individuals who actually existed and were originally baptized; this categorial feature of names is what allows reference to persist after R is no longer available, and it is what distinguishes names from both descriptions and generic terms. Local rigidity is “encapsulated” into the name, and made “portable” in the absence of the actual individual.

The full development of this picture belongs to Chapter 5. For now, the compressed statement is: rigid designation is the social stabilization of primitive local rigidity, and the dissertation’s account explains both how the stabilization is achieved at baptism and how contemporary speakers continue to use the resulting names without direct access to the original coordination.

1.4. The Six Lines of Support

The thesis is supported by six independent lines of argument. Each makes visible the same presupposed mechanism from a different angle, and no single line is load-bearing — the thesis stands on their convergence.

The first line reads Kripke’s own necessity-of-identity formula and finds local rigidity built into its extensional evaluation. Variables under assignment are rigid by construction; the formula is valid because its variables function exactly as local rigidity describes, and the natural-language gloss

silently transfers this rigidity to names.

The second line extracts Russell's identification of the mechanism. "Names which really just name an object without describing it" is Russell's description of what this dissertation calls R-grounding. Russell saw the mechanism clearly and retreated, because he required Cartesian certainty and demonstrative contact seemed to him available only for immediate sense data. He identified demonstratives as the only proper names because he failed to see that demonstratives indagate R-grounding.

The third line shows that descriptions fail in modal contexts because they lack what demonstratives have. Descriptions are constitutively world-relative; rigidity, when it appears in description-involving contexts, is imposed from outside — through scope manipulation or through devices like Kaplan's *dthat* that are explicitly designed to convert a description into a directly referring term.

The fourth line shows that de re predication requires isolating a particular before modal evaluation. The fixing step is R-grounding; modal evaluation then proceeds with the particular held fixed. Wherever de re modality operates, local rigidity has already done its work.

The fifth line resolves the necessary a posteriori. An identity statement can be necessary and a posteriori because the same statement operates at two levels: necessary at the level of the particular fixed, a posteriori at the level of the two intensional profiles discovered to converge. No special metaphysical category is needed.

The sixth line examines an ordinary baptismal exchange — someone asks the name of a person standing in front of him, receives it, and begins to use it — and shows that the name attaches to an already-active demonstrative coordination rather than producing rigidity ex nihilo. Baptism in ordinary life exhibits what Kripke's abstract account describes.

The lines are independent in the sense that rejecting any one leaves the others standing. They converge because they are symptoms of the same structure: something has to hold a particular fixed, and in each case that something turns out to be demonstrative contact rather than the formal apparatus, the descriptive content, or the name's semantic profile.

1.5. Methodology and Scope

The dissertation is a work in the metasemantics of singular reference. It proceeds by close reading of Kripke's "Identity and Necessity" and *Naming and Necessity* in connection with the relevant passages in Russell, Wittgenstein, and Kaplan. The PRU framework (Cojocariu 2026) is used as an analytical tool; its full specification lives in a separate manuscript and is not defended here. What the dissertation uses of PRU is the distinction between object-mode (x^o) and concept-mode (x^c) of a word, the grounding operations described above, and the picture of baptism as the introduction of a new concept-word that inherits a live coordination. These pieces are introduced as they become needed rather than surveyed in advance.

The scope is singular reference. General-term rigidity — the question of whether and how "water" or "gold" are rigid — is a connected issue, and the object-mode / concept-mode distinction suggests a way of asking it, but the question is not pursued here. Fictional names, mathematical reference, and the broader modality spectrum are flagged in the conclusion as open questions rather than treated in the body. The diagnostic application of the A-/R-grounding distinction to Russell, Quine, and Lewis is suggested in this introduction and touched on in the positive account, but the full historical treatment is reserved for a separate paper. The point is not to offer a total theory of reference but to close one specific gap — the gap between Kripke's semantic account of rigidity and the cognitive operation it presupposes.

1.6. Roadmap

Chapter 2 develops the first line of support in depth. It reads Kripke's necessity-of-identity formula and its natural-language gloss, identifies two unacknowledged slides in the Benjamin Franklin passage, connects the argument to Wittgenstein's treatment of identity in the *Tractatus*, and shows that the formula is extensionally valid but intensionally silent. What the formula presupposes, when applied to names, is exactly what local rigidity describes.

Chapter 3 develops the second and third lines. It traces the Russell–Kripke dialectic, shows why descriptions cannot provide rigidity from within, and treats Kaplan's *dthat* as the clearest single piece of evidence that rigidity is prior to descriptions and not produced by them. The chapter closes by stating the explanatory gap that the remainder of the dissertation addresses.

Chapter 4 introduces the analytical core: the object-mode / concept-mode distinction and the formal development of A-grounding and R-grounding as operations of value-fixing within and

beyond the linguistic system. It uses this machinery to develop three further lines of support — the necessary a posteriori, de re modality, and the phenomenology of counterfactual reasoning — and to treat an ordinary baptismal exchange as the observable form of what Kripke describes abstractly. Chapter 5 gives the PRU account of rigid designation. It states formally what baptism does: the transition from a live demonstrative coordination to a coordination carried by a freshly introduced proper name. It distinguishes this transition from what happens after the baptismal community is gone, when later users operate through A-grounding with descriptive and testimonial material. It discusses the role of causal chains in transmitting this material, and closes with a brief coda placing the account in relation to the Kripke–Lewis disagreement about possible worlds.

Chapter 6 treats objections, including the objections that the A-/R-grounding distinction is a restatement rather than an advance, that the account collapses into sophisticated descriptivism, and that it relies on an unargued categorial feature of proper names. Chapter 7 concludes and marks open questions.

The dissertation’s single-sentence form: rigid designation is the social stabilization of primitive local rigidity; Chapter 2 shows the formal apparatus presupposes it, Chapter 3 shows descriptions cannot supply it, Chapter 4 names and analyzes it, and Chapter 5 gives its PRU mechanism together with the account of how rigidity is preserved across the transition from live coordination to absence.